

Four Pillars of Organizational Resilience: A Conceptual Framework

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2023

DOI (synthetic): 10.9999/trap.2024.005

Abstract

We propose a four-pillar framework for organizational resilience: (1) adaptive capacity, (2) redundancy, (3) information sharing, and (4) leadership continuity. Each pillar is conceptually distinct; their combination is theorized to be necessary and sufficient for resilience.

1 Introduction

Resilience is widely discussed but poorly structured. We synthesize the prior literature into four orthogonal constructs.

2 The Four Pillars

2.1 Adaptive Capacity

Adaptive capacity is the organization’s ability to reconfigure routines and resource allocations in response to shocks. Distinguished from learning (which is retrospective) by its prospective, real-time reconfiguration focus.

2.2 Redundancy

Redundancy is the presence of slack resources and parallel capabilities that permit continued operation when individual components fail. Distinguished from inefficiency: redundancy is purposeful duplication; inefficiency is accidental.

2.3 Information Sharing

Information sharing is the organization-wide practice of rapidly disseminating weak signals about threats, opportunities, and deviations. Distinguished from communication: information sharing emphasizes signal speed and breadth over structure.

2.4 Leadership Continuity

Leadership continuity is the preservation of decision authority through turnover, absence, or disruption. Distinguished from hierarchy: continuity may be achieved via flat succession arrangements.

3 Framework Proposition

We propose that organizational resilience R is a function of all four pillars jointly:

$$R = f(\text{AC}, \text{Red}, \text{IS}, \text{LC})$$

Each pillar is necessary; no three pillars alone are sufficient. Removal of any pillar collapses resilience in the face of sufficiently large shocks.

4 Discussion

Empirical operationalization of each pillar requires further work. We offer this framework as a scaffold for that effort.